

The Low Countries

THE NETHERLANDS, BELGIUM, AND LUXEMBOURG are known as the Low Countries because the land is so flat and low-lying. In the case of the Netherlands, much of the land is below sea level—*Netherlands* is Dutch for “under lands.” The three countries are among the richest in Europe and, while farming still plays an important part, they all have strong, modern economies based on manufacturing and trade. Luxembourg in particular is known as a tax haven and is a major center for international finance. Their location at the mouth of the River Rhine and other major European rivers places the three countries at the heart of western European trade and politics—all three were founder members of the European Economic Community (now the European Union, or EU), established in 1957.

Tulips were introduced to the Netherlands from Turkey in 1562. Black tulips were the most valuable.

ROTTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

Every year, around 30,000 sea-going ships and 110,000 barges call at the port of Rotterdam. Lying at the mouth of the River Rhine, this port is the largest in the world and is where vast container ships from all over the world load or unload their cargoes. The smaller barges help to transport goods farther inland. With the port's advanced Vessel Traffic Service (VTS) it's possible to track ships on a radar screen up to 37 miles (60 km) off the coast and 25 miles (40 km) inland.

DUTCH PEOPLE

The Dutch once ruled a vast empire in Indonesia, the Caribbean, and South America. As a result, many nationalities now live here. Ethnic minorities make up about 15 percent of the people and in some cities, the majority of primary school children have a non-Dutch background.

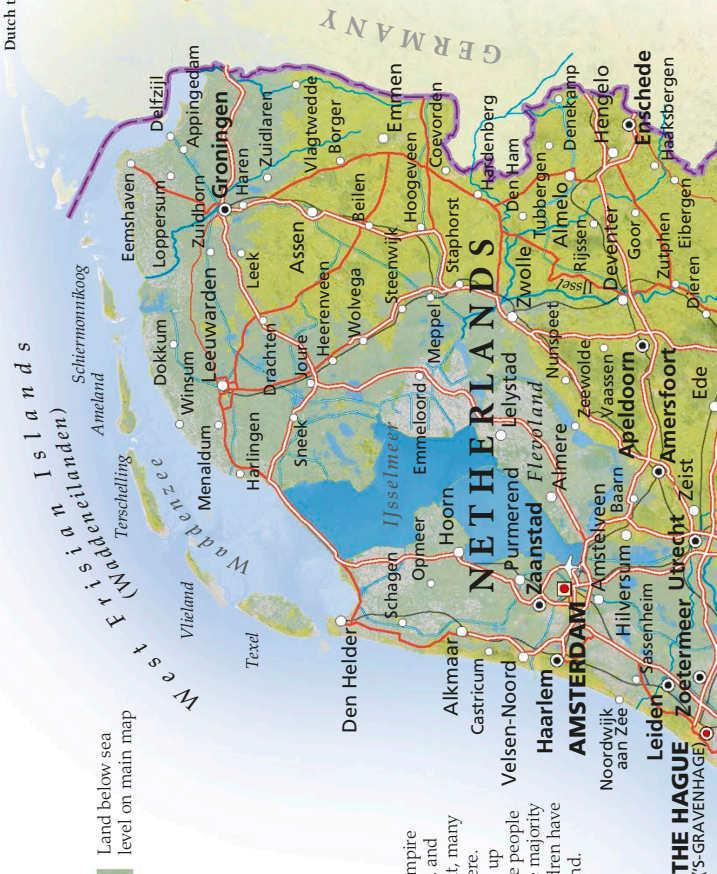
RECLAIMING THE LAND

Over the centuries, the Dutch have reclaimed land from the sea. They did this by building huge dykes, or dams, to keep out the sea, and then draining the surface water into canals. Windmills originally pumped out the water, but electric pumps are now used.

CROPS

Fertile soil and good irrigation have helped the Netherlands become a major exporter of agricultural products, with vegetables and tomatoes forming important crops. It is also famous for its bulbs and cut flowers, notably tulips.

Dutch tulips



Land below sea level on main map

